

Foundations of Muslim–non-Muslim relations in Islam

Analysis run: September 12, 2026

PROVIDER

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LENGTH

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0.7**SYSTEM PROMPT**

You are an expert AI content generator specializing in creating structured article.

USER PROMPT

Write a concise, self-contained article entry for the title: "Foundations of Muslim-non-Muslim relations in Islam".

Overall topic for alignment: Muslim-non-Muslim relations grounded in human dignity in sharia.

Important points to cover: Include Arabic terms, historical contexts, quranic foundations of sharia, minority and majority settings, Islamic theological schools, Islamic juristic schools of Hanafi, Hambali, shafi'i and Malaki, orientalist perspective, AI's humanistic approach to sharia, Human rights declaration..

- Output format: GitHub-Flavored Markdown. The markdown must be clean—do not include any code fences or surrounding markers. Target writing format: Blog Post. Follow these format-specific rules exactly:

- Aim for at least 6000 characters while staying under 12000. Prefer verifiable facts from the provided sources; do not fabricate citations or specific data.

- Place external links only in the "References" section; do not include inline external links in the body text.

- Maximum content length (including headings and references): 12000 characters. If nearing the limit, prioritize the most informative sections and keep references to 2-3.

- Write in the target response language. Avoid fluff; be precise and actionable. Do not include images or tables.

- Do not include code fences or any text outside the markdown content.

No external web sources are attached. Do not fabricate citations or specific facts that cannot be verified. Keep claims general and verifiable. In the 'References' section, include: "No external sources used."

****Respond in English****

SUMMARY

Muslim–non-Muslim relations in Islam are grounded in a moral and legal framework centered on human dignity (*karāmah insāniyyah*), justice (*‘adl*), mercy (*raḥmah*), covenantal responsibility (*‘ahd*), public welfare (*maṣlaḥah*), and the objectives of Islamic law (*maqāṣid al-sharī‘ah*). The Qur’an affirms the dignity of all descendants of Adam, commands justice even toward opponents, rejects compulsion in religion, permits kindness and fairness toward peaceful non-Muslims, and presents human diversity as part of divine wisdom.

A key distinction is between *sharī‘ah*, the ideal divine path, and *fiqh*, human juristic interpretation. Many historical rulings on non-Muslims were shaped by pre-modern political conditions such as empire, communal legal identity, and the absence of modern citizenship. Concepts such as *Ahl al-Kitāb*, *dhimmah*, *jizyah*, *amān*, *‘ahd*, and *ṣulḥ* reflected legal arrangements for protection, taxation, treaties, and coexistence, but they require contextual interpretation today.

Historically, Muslim societies included coexistence, intellectual exchange, trade, alliance, conflict, discrimination, and reform. The *dhimmah* system offered protection and communal autonomy to some non-Muslim groups but also reflected hierarchical political norms common in pre-modern societies. Modern debates ask whether such categories should be retained, reinterpreted, or replaced by equal citizenship (*muwāṭṭanah*) in constitutional states.

The issues differ in Muslim-majority and Muslim-minority contexts. In Muslim-majority settings, central questions concern minority protection, constitutional citizenship, public religious expression, education, worship, and family law. Many contemporary Muslim thinkers argue for citizenship-based equality. In Muslim-minority contexts, the focus shifts to lawful residence, civic loyalty, pluralism, neighborliness, and cooperation under non-Muslim governments. Older categories such as *dār al-Islām* and *dār al-ḥarb* are often viewed by contemporary scholars as products of earlier geopolitical realities, not simple guides for modern states.

Islamic theological and juristic traditions offer diverse tools for thinking about non-Muslims. Ash‘arī, Māturīdī, Mu‘tazilī, and Atharī approaches differ in method but affirm moral accountability and divine justice. The Hanafi, Maliki, Shafi‘i, and Hanbali schools developed rulings on treaties, trade, worship, taxation, marriage, war, peace, and governance, combining enduring principles with historically conditioned rules.

Modern human rights discourse overlaps with Islamic ethics in areas such as dignity, life, property, worship, due process, and welfare, while tensions remain around conversion, public morality, family law, and religion-state relations. A constructive modern approach should distinguish *sharī‘ah* from *fiqh*, center human dignity, respect scholarly diversity, account for context, avoid dehumanizing language, prioritize covenant and citizenship, and support peaceful disagreement.

The article argues that the strongest contemporary Islamic foundation for Muslim–non-Muslim relations combines fidelity to revelation with equal human dignity, justice, mercy, covenant-keeping, public welfare, and responsible citizenship.

FULL CONTENT

Foundations of Muslim–non-Muslim Relations in Islam

Muslim–non-Muslim relations in Islam are rooted in a broad moral framework that combines theology, law, ethics, and historical experience. At the center of this framework is the idea that every human being possesses dignity because all people are created by God. In Islamic vocabulary, this dignity is often linked to *karāmah insāniyyah* — human dignity — and to the Qur’anic description of humanity as honored: “We have certainly honored the children of Adam” (Qur’an 17:70).

The foundations of these relations are not reducible to conflict, tolerance, or legal hierarchy alone. They include principles of justice (*‘adl*), mercy (*rahmah*), public welfare (*maṣlaḥah*), covenantal responsibility (*‘ahd*), and protection of life, religion, property, intellect, and family, commonly discussed under the objectives of Islamic law, *maqāṣid al-sharī‘ah*.

Qur’anic Foundations of Sharia and Human Dignity

The Arabic term *sharī‘ah* originally refers to a path or way, and in Islamic usage it means the divinely guided path of moral and legal life. Its foundations are usually understood through the Qur’an, the *Sunnah* of the Prophet Muhammad, juristic reasoning, and inherited scholarly interpretation.

Several Qur’anic principles are central to Muslim–non-Muslim relations:

- **Human dignity:** All human beings share a common origin and are honored as descendants of Adam.
- **Justice:** The Qur’an repeatedly commands justice, including toward those with whom Muslims disagree. Qur’an 5:8 warns believers not to let hostility lead them away from justice.
- **Freedom of conscience:** Qur’an 2:256 states, “There is no compulsion in religion,” a verse frequently cited in discussions of religious freedom.
- **Peaceful coexistence:** Qur’an 60:8 states that God does not forbid Muslims from showing kindness and justice to those who do not fight them because of religion or expel them from their homes.
- **Religious diversity:** Qur’an 49:13 presents human diversity as part of divine wisdom, emphasizing mutual knowledge rather than contempt.

These verses do not eliminate all legal and political tensions in Islamic history, but they provide a normative foundation for relations based on dignity, fairness, and restraint.

Key Arabic Concepts

A balanced discussion requires attention to several Arabic terms:

- **Ummah:** The Muslim community, though in some early contexts it could refer to a broader political community.
- **Ahl al-Kitāb:** “People of the Book,” usually referring to Jews and Christians, and sometimes extended by jurists to other religious communities.
- **Dhimma:** A historical legal covenant of protection granted to non-Muslim subjects in Muslim-ruled lands.
- **Dhimmi:** A non-Muslim protected under the *dhimma* system.
- **Jizyah:** A historical tax associated with the protection and exemption of certain non-Muslim subjects from military service in classical Islamic polities.
- **Amān:** A grant of security or safe-conduct.
- **Ahd:** Covenant or treaty.
- **Ṣulḥ:** Peace agreement or reconciliation.
- **Muwāṭanah:** Citizenship, a modern concept increasingly used by Muslim scholars to describe equal belonging in a nation-state.
- **Fiqh:** Human understanding and interpretation of Islamic law.
- **Sharīʿah:** The ideal divine path; broader and more comprehensive than positive law.
- **Maqāṣid al-sharīʿah:** The higher objectives of Islamic law, including preservation of life, religion, intellect, property, lineage/family, and dignity.

A crucial distinction is between *sharīʿah* as an ideal moral order and *fiqh* as juristic interpretation. Many disagreements about Muslim–non-Muslim relations arise because historical *fiqh* rulings are sometimes treated as timeless divine commands, even though jurists often developed them in specific political circumstances.

Historical Contexts

Muslim–non-Muslim relations developed in varied historical settings. During the Prophet Muhammad’s time in Medina, Muslims lived alongside Jews, pagans, and other groups. The early Medinan community is often discussed as an example of covenantal politics, where different groups had duties and protections under a shared political arrangement.

As Muslim rule expanded, large non-Muslim populations lived under Muslim governments. Classical jurists developed rules for treaties, taxation, worship, public order, and intercommunal relations. These rules were shaped by pre-modern conditions: empire, communal identity, religiously defined political belonging, and the absence of the modern nation-state.

The *dhimma* system, for example, cannot be understood properly without its historical setting. It offered protection and communal autonomy to recognized non-Muslim groups, but it also reflected a hierarchical political order typical of many pre-modern societies. Modern debates ask whether such categories should be retained, reinterpreted, or replaced by equal citizenship (*muwāṭanah*) in constitutional states.

Islamic history includes examples of coexistence, intellectual exchange, trade, conflict, discrimination, alliance, and reform. No single historical episode can represent all Muslim–non-Muslim relations. The tradition is diverse and must be interpreted with attention to time, place, and legal purpose.

Majority and Minority Settings

Muslim–non-Muslim relations differ depending on whether Muslims are a majority or a minority.

In **Muslim-majority settings**, the key questions include:

- How should the state protect religious minorities?
- What is the relationship between Islamic law and constitutional citizenship?
- Can historical categories such as *dhimma* be reconciled with modern equal rights?
- How should public religious expression, family law, education, and worship be governed?

Many contemporary Muslim thinkers argue that the modern state requires a citizenship-based framework. Under this approach, non-Muslims are not merely protected communities but full citizens with equal civil dignity, legal security, and participation in public life.

In **Muslim-minority settings**, the questions are different:

- How should Muslims live faithfully under non-Muslim governments?
- What obligations do Muslims have toward the laws of their countries?
- How should Muslims engage in pluralistic societies?
- What is the Islamic basis for cooperation, neighborliness, and civic loyalty?

Classical Islamic law contained categories such as *dār al-Islām* and *dār al-ḥarb*, often translated as “abode of Islam” and “abode of war.” Some jurists also recognized intermediate or treaty-based categories. Contemporary scholars frequently argue that these categories were products of earlier geopolitical realities and should not be applied simplistically to modern states, especially where Muslims enjoy security, freedom of worship, and citizenship rights.

Theological Schools and Human Relations

Islamic theology has influenced how Muslims understand human dignity, moral responsibility, and relations with others. Major theological schools include:

- **Ash'arī theology:** Often associated with divine omnipotence and a cautious approach to human reason, while still affirming moral and legal responsibility.
- **Māturīdī theology:** Historically influential among many Hanafi communities, often giving a stronger role to reason in recognizing moral truths.
- **Mu'tazilī theology:** Known for emphasizing divine justice and human moral responsibility, though it became less institutionally dominant over time.
- **Atharī or traditionalist theology:** Emphasizes scripture and early community understandings, often with caution toward speculative theology.

These schools differ in method, but all accept that human beings are morally accountable and that justice is central to divine command. Their differences can affect how scholars reason about ethics, natural law, religious accountability, and the rights of non-Muslims.

Juristic Schools: Hanafi, Maliki, Shafi'i, and Hanbali

The four major Sunni juristic schools — **Hanafi**, **Maliki**, **Shafi'i**, and **Hanbali** (also spelled Hambali) — developed detailed legal discussions on relations with non-Muslims. These discussions covered treaties, trade, marriage, food, religious communities, taxation, war and peace, and diplomatic security.

Hanafi School

The Hanafi school, historically influential across Central Asia, South Asia, the Ottoman lands, and parts of the Arab world, is often noted for its developed reasoning on legal status, contracts, and governance. Hanafi jurists frequently emphasized legal security and the binding nature of covenants. In some areas, Hanafi doctrine was comparatively flexible in dealing with non-Muslim communities under Muslim rule.

Maliki School

The Maliki school, rooted in the practice of Medina and influential in North and West Africa, gave weight to communal practice and public welfare. Maliki legal reasoning often considered social order, custom, and the protection of the community. In modern discussions, Maliki tools such as *maṣlaḥah* are often invoked in arguments for public welfare and civic coexistence.

Shafi'i School

The Shafi'i school is known for its systematic theory of legal sources. Its founder, al-Shafi'i, helped shape the discipline of *uṣūl al-fiqh*, or legal methodology. Shafi'i discussions of Muslim–non-Muslim relations often emphasize textual grounding, legal categories, and careful interpretation of scriptural evidence.

Hanbali / Hambali School

The Hanbali school is often associated with strong attachment to textual evidence and early Muslim precedent. Yet Hanbali jurists also developed practical rulings for governance, treaties, and public order. Later Hanbali thought includes both strict and pragmatic strands, depending on historical context and scholarly method.

Across all four schools, it is important to distinguish between permanent moral principles and historically conditioned administrative rules. Justice, covenant-keeping, and protection of life are enduring principles. Specific political arrangements may vary by time and place.

Orientalist Perspectives

“Orientalist” perspectives refer broadly to Western academic, political, and cultural interpretations of Islam and Muslim societies, especially from the colonial and post-colonial periods. Some orientalist scholarship contributed valuable philological and historical research. However, other works presented Islamic law as rigid, static, or inherently hostile to non-Muslims.

A balanced approach avoids two errors. The first is romantic apologetics, which ignores real historical inequalities and conflicts. The second is reductionist criticism, which treats Islamic civilization as uniquely intolerant or incapable of pluralism. Muslim–non-Muslim relations should instead be studied through primary texts, legal diversity, social history, and comparative context. Pre-modern Christian, Jewish, Hindu, Buddhist, and secular empires also organized society through unequal legal categories. Islam should be examined critically but not in isolation from the norms of its historical world.

Human Rights Declarations and Islamic Law

Modern human rights language has shaped contemporary Muslim discussions. The **Universal Declaration of Human Rights** is widely recognized as a global moral and legal reference point for dignity, equality, conscience, and protection from discrimination. Some Muslim-majority states and scholars have also engaged with Islamic human rights documents, such as declarations that seek to frame rights within Islamic ethical and legal language.

The main area of debate is not whether humans have dignity, but how rights are grounded and interpreted. Secular human rights frameworks often ground rights in human autonomy, equality, and international consensus. Islamic frameworks often ground rights in divine creation, moral

accountability, and the objectives of *sharī'ah*. These approaches can overlap in many areas: protection of life, property, family, worship, due process, and human dignity. They may diverge in debates over conversion, public morality, family law, and the relationship between religion and state.

A constructive approach recognizes that *maqāṣid al-sharī'ah* can support strong commitments to dignity, justice, and welfare, while also requiring careful legal reasoning in areas where classical rulings conflict with modern rights expectations.

Toward a Humanistic Approach to Sharia in the Age of AI

An AI-informed humanistic approach to *sharī'ah* should not invent religious rulings or replace qualified scholarship. Rather, it can help clarify concepts, compare interpretations, identify historical context, and reduce polemical distortion.

Such an approach should follow several principles:

1. **Distinguish *sharī'ah* from *fiqh*.** The divine ideal is not identical to every historical legal opinion.
2. **Center human dignity.** Any interpretation affecting non-Muslims should be tested against Qur'anic commitments to justice, mercy, and human honor.
3. **Respect scholarly diversity.** The Hanafi, Maliki, Shafi'i, and Hanbali schools contain multiple views shaped by context.
4. **Account for minority and majority realities.** A ruling developed for empire may not apply directly to a modern constitutional democracy.
5. **Avoid dehumanizing language.** Terms such as *kāfir* have theological meanings but must not be used to deny basic human dignity or lawful rights.
6. **Prioritize covenant and citizenship.** Modern political life depends on trust, equal protection, and public responsibility.
7. **Support peaceful disagreement.** Islam recognizes moral conviction while also requiring justice toward those outside the faith.

AI can assist by presenting the tradition responsibly, but ethical judgment remains human. Religious interpretation requires knowledge, humility, and awareness of lived consequences.

Practical Foundations for Coexistence

A concise framework for Muslim–non-Muslim relations grounded in Islamic ethics may be summarized as follows:

- **Common humanity:** All people share origin, vulnerability, and dignity.
- **Justice before identity:** Religious difference does not justify oppression.
- **No compulsion in faith:** Belief must not be coerced.
- **Covenants must be honored:** Treaties, citizenship agreements, and promises carry moral weight.

- **Neighborliness is religiously meaningful:** Good conduct toward neighbors and colleagues is part of Islamic ethics.
- **Protection of worship and life:** Security for religious communities is consistent with Islamic legal objectives.
- **Scholarly interpretation must be contextual:** Classical rulings require careful application in modern realities.
- **Citizenship can express Islamic ethics:** Equal civic belonging may serve the objectives of justice and public welfare.

Conclusion

The foundations of Muslim–non-Muslim relations in Islam are complex but not incoherent. The Qur’an establishes human dignity, justice, freedom from compulsion, and moral accountability as central principles. Islamic history developed legal systems for managing diversity, some protective and some hierarchical by modern standards. The theological and juristic schools offer a rich but varied legacy that must be read with context.

In the modern world, the most persuasive Islamic approach is one that preserves fidelity to revelation while recognizing equal human dignity, citizenship, and the public good. Muslim–non-Muslim relations are strongest when grounded in *karāmah*, *‘adl*, *rahmah*, *‘ahd*, and *maṣlaḥah* — dignity, justice, mercy, covenant, and welfare.

SEGMENTED DATA (2)

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